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Sakshi Chaudhary



Women's 51kg

Before Sakshi Chaudhary became a Commonwealth Games champion, she first had to beat two world champions simply to make the Indian team. At the selection trials in Patiala in May, the Army boxer first stunned two-time world champion Nikhat Zareen 4-1 in the 51 kg semifinal. The following day, she beat reigning 48kg world champion Minakshi Hooda 5-0 in the final. The Commonwealth Games itself were almost a stroll in the park in comparison. She won all four of her bouts by unanimous decision, beginning with Botswana's Lethabo Modukanele, before beating Northern Ireland's Caitlin Fryers in the quarterfinal, Canada's Amber-Jane Wall in the semifinal and the highly rated English teenager Ruby White 5-0 in the final. White had entered the bout unbeaten in 68 contests before running into Sakshi. The gold was the perfect answer to those who would have felt Sakshi's was a career that had stalled just as it seemed ready to take off. A product of the famed Bhiwani Boxing Club, Chaudhary began boxing at 12 and won the World Junior Championships in 2015 before becoming a two-time World Youth champion in 2017 and 2018. She won an Asian Championships bronze in 2021, but a recurring shoulder injury robbed her of the 2022 Commonwealth Games, the 2023 Asian Games and a chance to qualify for the Paris Olympics. At 25 years old, with little to show at the senior level, Sakshi would



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find an extra gear. It came with reinvention. With Preeti Pawar securing India's 54kg berth, Chaudhary, who normally weighs around 56kg, dropped to 51kg, shedding almost three kilograms in three weeks along the way. The move gave her a crucial advantage: height, reach and the ability to control opponents from distance with her jab.

The boxing trials in Patiala established that Sakshi could beat the best Indian boxers under pressure. Glasgow merely confirmed that pedigree.



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Preeti Pawar



Women's 54kg

Preeti Pawar didn't set out wanting to be a boxer. At 13, the girl from Bhiwani was far more interested in studying and reluctant to even step into the ring. Her parents, both former athletes, persuaded her to give sport a chance. She only reluctantly took to boxing, training with her uncle Vinod Sai Pawar, who was himself a former national-level boxer turned coach. More than a decade later, Preeti is a Commonwealth Games champion. The 22-year-old's rise has been remarkably swift. She won bronze at the



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Hangzhou Asian Games in 2023, then despite suffering from a bout of Hepatitis A represented India at the Paris Olympics. In April this year, she became Asian champion after beating Paris Olympic bronze medallist Aeji Im and three-time world champion Huang Hsiao-wen on her way to the 54kg title. She had already won the 2025 World Boxing Cup Finals. At Glasgow, Preeti barely looked troubled. She stopped Malawi's Deborah Mtenje in the second round before beating Northern Ireland's Nicole Clyde 5-0 in the quarterfinals. She followed that with another unanimous victory over Catherine Mwape in the semifinal and then beat Canada's Scarlett Delgado 5-0 in the final, imposing a standing count along the way. There is an unusual side to Preeti. Away from the ring, she likes quilling and calligraphy. After her first-round victory at the Paris Olympics, she told reporters she would sketch the bout afterwards, using the drawing to analyse what she had done and what she could have done differently. After winning her own gold medal in Glasgow, she gifted a quilling artwork to long jumper Murali Sreeshankar, who won a silver medal himself. That penchant for creative flair perhaps adds to her technically sound boxing technique. Over the course of the Commonwealth Games she delivered a masterclass in movement, ring control and counter-punching. Still early in her career, Preeti is only getting better with every tournament. The reluctant teenager is long gone. In her place is an Olympian, an Asian champion and now a Commonwealth champion who has her sights firmly set on Los Angeles 2028.